

## Stack B: Bodyguard Rule Fix

Version: 2026-04-25. Based on baseline rules v2026-04-25.

Feedback form (fill out after the game): [stack-b-feedback.pdf](#)

**One change from baseline.** Only the Bodyguard Rule adjacency requirement is different. Independent of Stack A — run any time. Carry all accepted changes (Layer 1 economy) forward.

*Designer notes — read before facilitating, players can skip.*

**What we're testing:** Does loosening the Bodyguard adjacency requirement to “adjacent to defender only” make the rule actually trigger and Guards genuinely useful?

**Hypothesis:** “Adjacent to both attacker AND defender” was too restrictive. “Adjacent to defender only” makes Guard positioning much simpler and the rule much more likely to fire.

**Watch for:**

- Does the Bodyguard rule trigger? How many times per game?
- Do players actively position Guards to protect Champions/King?
- Does it feel too easy to bodyguard? Is a 1-Guard wall impenetrable?
- Do Guards survive longer or die faster?

All rules below are current baseline. The only changed section is marked ⚡.

### Goal

Capture the opponent's **King**. The game ends immediately when a King is removed from the board.

#### Draw conditions:

- No piece has been captured for 10 consecutive full rounds.
- Only the two Kings remain on the board.

### Components

**Per player:** 1 King · 5 Champions · 6 Guards

**Shared (Prototype):** 10x10 grid board · Skill cards · Injured markers · Armor pieces

### Skill Drafting

- Lay out all available skills face-up as a shared pool.
- Alternating draft: P1 picks 2 skills from the pool and assigns them freely to any of their Champions or King → P2 picks 2 skills and assigns freely → repeat.
- Continue until all 5 Champions and the King on each side have 2 skills.
- Both players draft from the same pool. Duplicates are allowed.

### Setup

- **Board:** Use the 10x10 grid.
- **First player:** Flip a coin (or decide verbally).
- **Piece placement:** Each player places pieces on their own back two rows:
  - Back row (row 1/10): King in the centre, Champions fill the remaining 5 spaces.
  - Second row (row 2/9): All 6 Guards.
- **Skill Draft:** Alternating picks. P1 picks 2 skills from the pool and assigns them freely to any of their Champions or King, then P2. Repeat until all Champions and the King on each side have 2 skills each (12 per player). Duplicates allowed.
- **Starting Runes:** Each player starts with **6 Runes**.
- P1 begins Round 1.

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## Round Structure

A **Round** = P1's Turn + P2's Turn.

At the **start of each player's turn** (before they do anything), that player collects their Rune income. (*Exception: Round 1 — players begin with their starting Runes and collect nothing before their first turn.*)

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## Turn Structure

Each **Turn** has two phases, in order:

- **Movement Phase** — spend Move Slots to move pieces (and attack).
- **Action Phase** — spend Skill Slots to activate skills.

You may use 0 slots in either phase.

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## Movement Phase

You have **2 Move Slots** per turn. Spend 1 Move Slot to move one piece. **Each piece may only be moved once per Movement Phase.**

| Piece           | Normal speed | Injured speed |
|-----------------|--------------|---------------|
| Guard           | 2 tiles      | 1 tile        |
| Champion / King | 1 tile       | 1 tile        |

**Free pathing:** A piece may move in any direction — horizontal, vertical, diagonal — taking any route up to its speed in tiles. The route does not have to be a straight line.

**Pieces block movement:** A moving piece cannot pass through any other piece, ally or opponent.

- *Exception:* A piece may go around a blocking piece if total tiles moved stays within speed (e.g. a Guard using 2 diagonal moves to go around a piece directly in the way).
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## Standard Attack

To attack, spend a Move Slot to move your piece **onto a tile occupied by an enemy piece.**

- Deal **1 DMG** to the enemy.
- **If the enemy is removed:** your piece occupies the tile.
- **If the enemy survives** (Armor absorbed the damage): your piece stops on the tile immediately before the target. (*If there are multiple paths toward the target then you are allowed to choose which one you want to take (important for Bodyguard Rule)*)

You may attack with one Move Slot and move a different piece with the other Move Slot in the same turn.

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## Action Phase

You have **2 Skill Slots** per turn (at the start (see Progression)).

Spend 1 Skill Slot to activate one equipped skill on one of your Champions or King:

- Announce the skill and the target.
- Pay the skill's Rune cost.
- Apply the skill's effect.

The same Champion can activate multiple skills (also the same one) in one turn if you have Skill Slots remaining.

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## Skill System

**Skill Path:** Skills travel in a **straight line** (horizontal, vertical, or diagonal) from the caster, like a chess Queen.

**Blocking:** The Skill Path is blocked by **all pieces** — ally and opponent alike. The skill cannot reach past the first piece in its path.

**Range:** The distance in tiles along the Skill Path from caster to target. Range is measured as:

- Range 0 = self (caster's own tile)
- Range 1 = adjacent tile along Skill Path
- Range 2 = 2 tiles away along Skill Path (etc.)

**Default Range = 2.** Unless a skill explicitly names “self” or “adjacent” in its effect text. A skill with a Range modifier (e.g. “Range –1”) is still a Range 2 skill with a modifier applied — it is not treated as adjacent or self.

**Self vs. adjacent:** “Self” skills (Range 0) target only the caster — they cannot target adjacent pieces, even with a Range buff. “Adjacent” skills (Range 1) target only neighbouring pieces — they cannot target the caster, even with a Range buff. Range buffs (e.g. Focus Strike) shift the targeting window outward; they do not collapse it inward.

**Injured Range penalty:** Injured pieces have Skill Range –1. Skills that explicitly name “self” or “adjacent” in their text are unaffected — they always work regardless of Injured status.

**Skills that move pieces do not deal damage.** Movement-via-skill (Quick Dash, Shadow Shift, Retreat Plan) does not count as a Standard Attack and deals no damage on arrival - you are instead stopped from moving the piece further in that direction.

**A Champion may use its skills multiple times in the same turn** if Skill Slots are available — including the same skill twice.

All skills cost 1 Skill Slot unless noted otherwise.

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## Resource Economy (Runes)

**Starting Runes:** 6 per player.

Rune income is collected at the **start of each player's own turn:**

| Round | Income per player turn  |
|-------|-------------------------|
| 1     | 0 (starting Runes only) |
| 2-4   | +2                      |
| 5-9   | +3                      |
| 10-14 | +4                      |
| 15+   | +5 (+1 every 5 rounds)  |

**No Rune cap.**

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## Progression

| Round | Skill Slots per turn   |
|-------|------------------------|
| 1-10  | 2                      |
| 11-20 | 3                      |
| 21-30 | 4                      |
| 31+   | 5 (+1 every 10 rounds) |

## Health & Armor

**All pieces have 2 HP:** Normal → Injured → Removed.

| State   | HP | Effect                                                     |
|---------|----|------------------------------------------------------------|
| Normal  | 2  | No penalty                                                 |
| Injured | 1  | Speed capped at 1. Skill Range -1 (affects Range 2+ only). |
| Removed | 0  | Piece leaves the board permanently.                        |

### Damage:

- 1 DMG to Normal → Injured.
- 1 DMG to Injured → Removed.
- 2 DMG to Normal → Removed instantly (Injured state is skipped).

**Armor:** Max 3 points per piece. Each absorbs 1 DMG, then destroyed. Resolves before HP damage. **Does not prevent Injured status.**

## ⚡ CHANGED: Bodyguard Rule

|                           | Baseline                                    | This Layer           |
|---------------------------|---------------------------------------------|----------------------|
| Guard must be adjacent to | <b>Both tile-before-target AND defender</b> | <b>Defender only</b> |
| Everything else           | —                                           | Unchanged            |

When you make a **Standard Attack** against an opponent's Champion or King, the defender may choose to have a Guard intercept — **if** a friendly Guard is on a tile **adjacent to the defending piece** (*baseline requires adjacent to both the tile immediately before the target AND the defending piece*).

### Interception:

1. Defender announces a Guard to intercept.
2. The Guard takes the damage instead of the original target.
3. The attacker moves **1 tile** toward the target (stops on the tile immediately before the Guard, not before the original target).

**Interception is optional.** The defender may decline even if a Guard is eligible.

Only Standard Attacks can be intercepted. Skills always hit directly.

### Example:

```
. . . . .
. G . . .
. . C . .   C = your Champion, G = your Guard, A = enemy piece
. . . A .
. . . . .
```

Enemy A attacks Champion C. Your Guard G is adjacent to C (but not to A). Under baseline this would not qualify — under this layer it does. You intercept: A moves 1 tile toward C, G takes the damage, C is safe.

## Skill Drafting

- Lay out all available skills face-up as a shared pool.
- Alternating draft: P1 picks 2 skills from the pool and assigns them freely to any of their Champions or King → P2 picks 2 skills and assigns freely → repeat.
- Continue until all 5 Champions and the King on each side have 2 skills.
- Both players draft from the same pool. Duplicates are allowed.

## Skill Reference

|                                                                                     | Cat.   | Name             | Cost | Effect                                                                                                                                                   |
|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------|------------------|------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
|    | Strike | Lance Thrust     | 2    | Target within Range-1 takes 1 DMG                                                                                                                        |
|    | Strike | Hook Pull        | 3    | Target takes 1 DMG, pulled 1 tile toward caster along Skill Path                                                                                         |
|    | Strike | Armor Breaker    | 2    | Remove 1 Armor from target. <i>(Note: does not deal "HP-Damage" unless boosted by Blade Call)</i>                                                        |
|    | Strike | Rune Theft       | 3    | Target takes 1 DMG. Steal 1 Rune from opponent.                                                                                                          |
|    | Strike | Blade Tempest    | 4    | Target takes 1 DMG. All pieces adjacent to the target are pushed 1 tile away from the target. The attacker/caster is not affected.                       |
|    | Shield | Rust Shield      | 2    | Self: gain +1 Armor                                                                                                                                      |
|    | Shield | Field Medic      | 3    | Remove Injured from one adjacent ally                                                                                                                    |
|    | Shield | Armorsmith       | 3    | Adjacent ally gains +1 Armor                                                                                                                             |
|    | Move   | Quick Dash       | 3    | Self: move up to 2 tiles along Skill Path                                                                                                                |
|    | Move   | Air Blast        | 2    | Push target enemy 1 tile directly away from caster                                                                                                       |
|    | Move   | Precision Thrust | 3    | Push target enemy 1 tile in any direction (caster chooses). <b>Range+1.</b>                                                                              |
|    | Move   | Shadow Shift     | 4    | Swap position with an allied piece. Requires unobstructed Skill Path.                                                                                    |
|   | Move   | Retreat Plan     | 4    | Self: move along Skill Path to land adjacent to one of your Guards. <b>Range+1.</b>                                                                      |
|  | Mystic | Focus Strike     | 1    | The next skill used by <b>any of your pieces</b> this turn gains +1 Range. <i>(Note: can boost self and adjacent skills — Range 0 → 1, Range 1 → 2.)</i> |
|  | Mystic | Blade Call       | 3    | One Strike skill used by <b>any of your pieces</b> this turn deals +1 DMG.                                                                               |

## Quick Reference

| Concept                  | Rule                                                                                                                     |
|--------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Movement                 | Free pathing, ≤ speed in tiles, cannot pass through pieces. Each piece once per phase.                                   |
| Attack                   | Move onto enemy tile (1 Move Slot). <b>1 DMG.</b>                                                                        |
| Attack — target survives | Attacker stops on tile before target                                                                                     |
| Skill Path               | Straight line (Queen). Blocked by all pieces.                                                                            |
| Default Skill Range      | Range 2 (unless skill specifies)                                                                                         |
| Bodyguard ⚡              | Guard adjacent to <b>defender only</b> . Guard takes the damage. Attacker moves 1 tile. Standard Attacks only. Optional. |
| Rune income              | Start of YOUR turn (not Round 1). 6 start, +2/+3/+4/+5 scaling.                                                          |
| Healing                  | No cap. Same piece can be healed multiple times per turn.                                                                |
| Armor                    | Armor absorbs damage first, then HP                                                                                      |